

GALLERIES

By Lee Fleming October 1, 1994

In "Filter Media," Jim Sanborn's show at Nancy Drysdale Gallery, the artist addresses the many meanings of such words as "shadows," "light," "balance" and "deceit." Common to all of the exhibit's sculptures are metal sheets that have been pierced repeatedly by the letters of a particular word. These punch-outs reduce the metal to a kind of dense mesh, so that the words -- most of them in foreign languages -- are virtually unreadable. But when a light that's part of the installation shines through the mesh, legible shadows of the letters are cast onto the floor or wall.

The sculptures -- made of rods, lenses, pierced copper sheets and, in one case, a telescope -- look simple, resembling skinny tables or small folded screens. But the light projections, which add layers of shadows, give the works complexity and compel viewers to notice small details.

These sculptures are about metaphors, both visual and verbal. The "Deceit Filters" present an imaginary way to filter out duplicity. But the large holes in the copper screening renders them ineffective. Apparently, nothing can really filter out deception.

Unfortunately, the "Deceit Filters," like a number of the larger "Decoding" and "Minutia" filters also on display, suffer from sameness. Sanborn's inquisitive talent is better showcased in the show's more eccentric, complex works. One of them is "Inclinare/Aequus," which incorporates the Latin words for biased (or tilted) and unbiased (or even). The two title words are cut into the topmost of three metal sheets that are positioned one over the other between thin rods (the work resembles an elegant plant stand). The middle sheet, onto which light casts the repeated word "inclinare," is tilted, as if demonstrating the meaning of that word. Beneath it, the third sheet is level, illustrating the "evenness" of the word "aequus," which is projected through a small mesh square in the metal above. The visual play between the meaning of the words and the configuration of the sculpture is extremely effective.

Jason Yi at Henri

Jason Yi's sculpture show at Henri Gallery revels in the beauty of unlikely materials -- rusted metal, twigs, thick rope and even braided hair -- combined in constructions that recall tools and machines. However, these assemblages obviously have no real function -- only what the viewer may imagine for them.

A long floor piece, "No Compromise," stretches thin rust-brown rods between two lengths of roughly shaped wood. It resembles a primitive harp or dulcimer. Yet the tautness of the "wires" and the nails studding parts of the wood also hint at stress and pain -- physical and psychological.

Similar emotional undertones darken all of Yi's pieces. In "My Loss," a pale human plait lies on top of a rusted metal box; a yellow rope emerges from an opening in the box side. The before-and-after connection between the braided hair and the braided rope is unmistakable. But what personal relationship has been transformed or destroyed?

Nakashima, Abbott at Anton

Tom Nakashima's six large new prints at Anton combine demanding printmaking techniques -- delicate-lined copperplate engraving and intaglio, watery collographs and lithography -- with hand-applied coloring and collage. The results are superb.

In each composition, Nakashima creates a realm of floating, mystical images that occasionally allude to everyday reality, which is symbolized by strips of newsprint bearing contemporary headlines. The fish and turtles that in the past have drifted through his paintings and across his screens are still here in these new works, no less ethereal or mysterious.

Unlike many of his colleagues, Nakashima clearly has no difficulty retaining his hallmarks -- transparency, quasi-religious symbols and the sense that his objects exist under water -- as he moves between painting and printmaking. But the show includes a vivid departure from the artist's usual subdued, aqueous tones: "Hanging Fish/After Giotto: Sanctuary," a four-color lithograph on hand-layered newspaper. This brilliant melange of color and newsprint holds an added level of interest for art historians. Nakashima's innovative, fine-art use of a commercial printing process pays homage to Giotto, the 13th/14th-century Italian master many consider the first modernist.

Upstairs at Anton, Rebecca Phillips Abbott explores the effect of the wind on objects and elements of the landscape in "The Wind," a large series of small selenium and cyanotype photographs. (These antique photographic processes produce silver and blue images, respectively.)

Sometimes the images are so subtle as to be stultifying. Numerous blurred, silvery-gray studies of a copy of The Washington Post being driven along the ground by a wayward breeze hold limited charm. Occasionally, however, she produces a truly riveting image: The deep, rich blues of the cyanotypes "Trees" #1 and #2 create exquisite nocturnes that hark back to photography's early years.

Jim Sanborn: Filter Media at Nancy Drysdale Gallery, 2103 O St. NW, through Oct. 8. \$1,800-\$12,000.

Jason Yi at Henri Gallery, 1500 21st St. NW, through Oct. 6. \$1,200-\$2,500.

Tom Nakashima/Rebecca Phillips Abbott at Anton Gallery, 2108 R St. NW, through Oct. 6. \$400-\$4,000.

The Post Recommends

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A visit to the "university" in 2007.
